



behind the United States out of 193 countries in the Open section, India's campaign at the Chess Olympiad was unblemished. The quintet of D. Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi, R. Praggnanandhaa, Vidit Gujrathi and Pentala Harikrishna dominated the proceedings, winning 10 of its 11 rounds while sharing the spoils only once — against defending champion Uzbekistan in the third-last round.

Praggnanandhaa led the charge on the top board, while Gukesh sat out the first round. India cruised past

Morocco and Iceland with identical 4-0 victories, sweeping all eight games in the opening two rounds.

In round three, India faced Hungary's B team. Vidit, playing with the black pieces, was held to a draw by Gabor Papp, ending India's perfect win streak. In the same round, Peter Prohászka faced the wrath of Arjun on the third board. Playing with the white pieces in a Queen's Gambit Declined game, Arjun forced his opponent into mistakes before sacrificing his queen

for a brilliant checkmate, which Prohászka graciously allowed. Arjun sealed the game in just 36 moves, validating his team captain Srinath Narayanan's decision to play him on Board 3.

"The great thing was that all the players were happy to do what was best for the team. So there was no pushback from anyone wanting to play on a fixed board. Chess-wise, it was straightforward: Gukesh and Pragg have been facing elite opponents with ratings of around